

A STAGE IS SET
(From left) Sharad Pawar, Om Prakash Chautala, Nitish Kumar, Tejashwi Yadav and others at a rally in Fatehabad, Haryana, on September 25

PTI

ers have lasted over an hour. Insiders describe the discussions as candid, with Nitish drawing on his experience and stature to emphasise the urgent need to come together. Then there is the matter of prime ministership. Nitish has repeatedly said that he is not a PM candidate. On September 26, he told mediapersons that he had no electoral ambitions in UP for the LS polls. "It is not about me. It never was," he said, insisting that his solitary focus is on uniting the opposition.

While Nitish has not gone into the specifics of his meetings in his media interactions, those in the know of JD(U) strategy explain the plan. "It might sound like oversimplification, but the fact is that the BJP, at the peak of its popularity, got about 38 per cent votes in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. It means 62 per cent of the electorate still voted against the BJP. A part of our idea is to consolidate these voters," says a JD(U) leader.

Those with access to the CM's inner circle also add that of the 303 seats that the BJP won in 2019, just 12 states, including Bihar, alone contributed 262 seats, or 87 per cent of the BJP's Lok Sabha strength.

These states are Assam (9 seats), Bihar (17), Gujarat (26), Haryana (10), Karnataka (25), Madhya Pradesh (28), Maharashtra (23), Rajasthan (24), Uttar Pradesh (62), West Bengal (18), Chhattisgarh (9) and Jharkhand (11).

The JD(U) think-tank believes that the law of averages might bring down BJP numbers in some states where it had done exceedingly well, and where there is little room to improve. Like in Rajasthan, where it had won 24 of 25 Lok Sabha seats in 2019, MP (28 of 29 seats), Karnataka (25 of 28 seats), Haryana (all 10 seats), Gujarat (all 26 seats) and Jharkhand (11 of 14 seats). The BJP, according to the strategy, has to be challenged hard in these states.

Besides, in Tamil Nadu (with a total 39 LS seats), Kerala (20 seats), Telangana (17), Andhra Pradesh (25), Bihar (40), Punjab (13), Odisha (21) and West Bengal (42), the BJP is yet to find firm ground. Part of the plan is to keep it that way, through formidable alliances.

HURDLES FOR AN OPPOSITION FRONT

- The BJP is a force to reckon with and the opposition still appears to be a divided lot
- Till now, the opposition hasn't projected a charismatic leader to take on PM Modi
- Opposition unity is a vexed question. Leaders like Om Prakash Chautala, Sukhbir Singh Badal and Arvind Kejriwal have a long history of fighting the Congress
- It will be difficult to convince the Congress to let regional players call the cards in states like Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal
- Opposition alliances have only succeeded in Bihar. The 2017 SP-Congress alliance for the UP assembly polls and the SP-BSP tie-up for the 2019 Lok Sabha polls failed

THE BIG CHALLENGES

Having taken oath as Bihar chief minister for the eighth time on August 10, Nitish has already become the longest-serving in that role. He has little left to prove in state politics. In fact, he made his intentions plain from day one, when he told media-persons shortly after taking oath: "Those who won in 2014 should be concerned if